Here in This House

By Christopher Scarpo

A sheltered teen - 16 years old

GIRL: **(Pgs 23-31)** It's not like I had huge plans for the summer or anything, but that did not mean I was all about spending a month in the wilderness at Happy Faces Summer Camp. Aren't camps for 12-year-olds, not high school kids? Whatever. Goodbye Fashion Square Mall and all night makeover parties with my friends and hello to spending a month in the forest, getting to know God better. And hello to bugs -- lots of bugs. Really big ones that always seemed to find a way into my cabin. But God says love all things equally, and I guess that includes centipedes. *(beat)* I've known God forever; but the whole point at Happy Faces was to help you get even closer to the Big Man Upstairs.

So, in between roasting holy marshmallows to go on sacred s'mores and swimming in the river filled with creepy underwater bugs, we spent lots of time reading the Bible and doing arts and crafts. We had to draw a picture of Jesus, but I can't really, like draw, so my picture of Jesus looked like a person with a stick body and a potato for a head. But I explained to the camp counselor that what really mattered was that you had to have Jesus in your heart, then he would forgive all of your sins, even drawing him to look like a potato. Oh my god, I totally love Jesus! The counselor told me that I shouldn't be saying, "Oh my god." She looked at me with this really intense look and said something about me having some quiet time and drawing another picture of Jesus as a vegetable.

The two most amazing things I learned at Happy Faces Summer Camp were 1) God totally believes in me, and knows I can do anything, even if it seems tough and 2) He's gonna love me no matter what. I really like knowing that.

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INTRODUCTION

In the 1990s and 2000s, a Christian movement now known as "purity culture" reached its height in America. During this period, a prolific industry of purity-themed bibles, rallies and books emerged. Sales of purity rings increased, worn as a symbol of commitment to sexual purity. Purity pledges were signed by teenagers to demonstrate their vow of abstinence. Beyond abstinence, young Christians were encouraged not to date. Young women and girls were instructed to be careful how they dressed and interacted with others to avoid "tempting" men, and strict gender roles were encouraged. But a sheltered life does not necessarily lead to a safe life.

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GIRL: So, anyway, school starts again and I decide that in between trying to get a 4.0 GPA and scoring fifteen hundred on the SAT, that I had another really big goal. "Mom, Dad, I think I'm ready to start dating." And Mom and Dad totally silent like . . . potatoes. Then, Mom tells me that Jesus wants me to focus on my grades and Dad tells me that I can date when I get married. I don't think my husband, or Jesus for that matter, would really be down with me dating after I got married! Then Dad tells me boys are really bad, and I'm getting the picture that Mom and Dad don't like boys at all -- no-way, no how, no go, no dating ***ever.*** Later that night, I had some quiet time with you-know-who and explained that now that I was a junior in high school, I should probably go on a date. And I think he understood, which was a huge relief. *(beat)* I know it's a sin to lie to your Mom and Dad but, uh, I thought about it. If I just didn't say anything then that wasn't lying at all, and Jesus would probably be okay with it.

The next day at school I talk to my two best friends and I explain that I'm ready to start dating. And Clarissa asks, "What about Jesus?" And Marissa asks, "What about your parents?" Jesus is totally fine with it and my parents don't need to know! Marissa suggests that we like have an audition or something. Drama club is for losers! And then Clarissa says we should start taking applications. Um, I'm not Burger King! Sometimes [they]are clueless. I decide there has to be an easier way. So, after 4th period, I go up to Lucky at his locker . . . *(awkwardly nervous)* "Hey, Lucky, hi! I was wondering if, well . . . if you would like go out on a date." I was nervous but I don't think he could tell. Everybody made such a deal

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out of this whole process and it was really easy.

Friday night comes and I change my outfit seven times and after looking in the mirror to make sure I didn't look like a potato, I like went out on my first date. I told my parents I had a school project to work on. We went to Grace's and I had a pineapple coke . . . I was really nervous. And Lucky wasn't weirded out at all. He told me how it is to be on the football team and how his older brother is a football star at college, and I looked at him, "very intently and nodded my head once every few words" -- that was some advice I got on this dating site. Then we held hands for a few minutes and then the date was over. And I'm thinking, that was not sinful at all. Maybe my parents just don't remember how dating is. I was grateful that Jesus had been able to guide me in the right direction. [But] I was really worried about asking Lucky on a second date. *(beat, with excitement)* Two days later, he asked ***me***! Wow! And then he asks again, and again. *(knowingly)* According to GirlDate.com after date number five, you're boyfriend and girlfriend.

Okay, so it's Saturday night, and Lucky takes me to Red Lobster, which is really fancy for high school, right? So, I know this is going to be a special night. While we're eating our fried shrimp, he presents me this box. I unwrap it and there's these silver hoop earrings. Lucky tells me that he'd been saving up forever for them, and I'm thinking that they look a lot like the ones you can get at the drugstore for two dollars. But it's the thought that counts. And then, okay, get this, Lucky tells me that he loves me!

We drive around for a while; Lucky parks the car and tells me he wants to talk for a little while. I'm pretty nervous, so I say a little prayer, asking God to help me with the right things to say, 'cause I'm thinking, after tonight, Lucky is gonna be my husband someday. And then, Lucky tells me that tonight we're gonna do more than hold hands. *(excited)* Oh, my go . . . goodness! I'm gonna have my first kiss tonight. And just like I thought, Lucky starts kissing me. But, it's not like little peck kisses, it's like the open mouth kind and at first it was okay . . . but then I'm trying to back away. Lucky holds me by the back of my head and tells me, "I'm so glad you're ready." If he meant ready for ***this***, I am soooo not ready and maybe will ***never*** be

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ready. I'm saying to Lucky that this is enough for tonight but he's telling me he loves me over and over. I'm like, okay, I get it, roger that! But, and I don't even know how, his hands are under my shirt and pressing and squeezing and I'm thinking back to GirlDate.com. I say, "That's enough, Lucky. Please stop." But, I guess he was loving me so much right then that he didn't even hear me.

He was on top of me and his hands aren't under my shirt anymore, they're, uh . . . lower. He was pulling my jeans off. *(crying)* "Stop, Lucky. Please stop." And, then, he, um. . . he well, he was right there . . . right where he wasn't supposed to be at all. And there's a lot of pushing, and my whole body feels as flat as paper or like a really heavy rock. It hurt the worst of any hurt my body could feel . And all of a sudden, I feel my Mom and y Dad and Jesus too were in the backseat of Lucky's car, saying, "Tada! -- This is why." And then Lucky lifts himself off and his face is sweaty and gross. I don't think he even noticed I was crying, 'cause he says, "That's how it's supposed to be. When you're in love." And he does his jeans up and um, he drives me home.

And um, we're both totally silent. I just go to bed, thinking when I wake up it's all gonna make sense, or just go away like a bad dream. But I wake up and it's even worse. I'm thinking, okay, so now I've had the dating experience, and we'll just move on from this, right? But within two days at school, everybody knows about it, and Marissa won't even sit next to me at lunch and after 4th period, somebody has left this sign on my locker that says . . . SLUT. Everywhere I walk a thousand voices whispering. When Clarissa finally talks to me, she tells me that Lucky broke up with me and he's dating Alexis now. Well, that's just great!

Lucky stops me on the way past his locker on the 4th day and asks me, "You know why they call me Lucky?" I'm just staring down, shaking my head, I can't even look at him. He opens his locker, and on the back wall, there's this list written in black sharpie pen. It's a list of girls' names -- name after name, and at the bottom of the list, the last name -- the last name is mine. Lucky just smiles at me and says, *(mockingly)* "I love you." And then he starts laughing. I get home from school, and Mom and Dad are home from work already,

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which is not like them; they both usually work 'til really late. It looks like Mom had been crying and Dad is not happy. Mrs. Henderson, she goes to our church, called my Mom. She knew all about everything. And my Mom asks me, "How could you do this to us?" And my Dad asks, "How could you do this to Jesus?" And I'm thinking, how could ***Lucky*** do this to ***me***! My Dad backhands me across the face -- he hasn't done that for a really long time, and then he says that I have ruined my body and that no husband would ever want me. Basically, I'm going to hell, and that, here in this house, they can't have that. Then they're talking about what this is going to do to my little brother and maybe they're going to have to send me away. And they don't mean Happy Faces Summer Camp.

So, I came here because I know that God's house never closes. I haven't been here for a long time, and it's weird 'cause my parents talk about God all the time, but we never come to visit his house -- like ever. This is the first time my brain has been quiet since this whole thing started. And I think God understands that I've been trying. I do want to go to a good college. And I realize that 3.9 isn't a 4.0 and that I really need to get a 1500 next time instead of a 1480; but the point is, I really try to do what my parents tell me. I just wanted to see a movie with a boy, you know? Maybe if Mom or Dad had told me about boys . . . well, I guess that doesn't really matter now, does it?

But, here in ***this*** house, I really think God thinks I'm beautiful and that I can do whatever I put my mind to. God and I are still good. And so I ask him, if maybe he can talk to my parents -- maybe explain that I'm sorry I let that stuff happen with Lucky. I didn't mean to. . . I totally didn't mean to. I wish it hadn't happened. *(looks up at the windows)* I forget how *beautiful* the stained glass is here. Everything in those pictures is perfect. I guess life just isn't sometimes, like when your picture of Jesus looks like a potato. I think I'm gonna just *be* here in the quiet for a little longer.

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AWARD HISTORY

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https://theconversation.com/the-impact-of-christian-purity-culture-is-still-being-felt-including-in-britain-182907

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